

faces rather than the more popular NURBS modelling technique, which lets you make very nuanced changes to your hull easily.

It offers you the features you'll need to work with hulls in other 3D programs—you import and export parts of or complete models in popular formats like .3ds. It also comes bundled with Wizards to construct the rest of your ship—keels and rudders, for example. It isn't all about silly boats though—FREE!ship also comes with features that calculate the performance of the hulls if actually submerged in water, so if daddy gives you enough money to build a *real* boat someday, and if you have the skill, you'll know the best hull design well in advance.

FREE!ship comes as an executable for the Windows platform, but works just as well with Wine in Linux.

Site: www.freeship.org

4.3.4 POV-Ray

POV-Ray (the Persistence of Vision Raytracer) is essentially a program for raytracing 3D scenes rather than modelling them. While it is open source in that you're free to download and modify the source code, it isn't licensed under the GNU-GPL. The gist of the matter is that you can modify it all you want, as long as you're doing it for yourself—the restrictions come in when distributing this modified code.

To create scenes in POV-Ray, you need to use its Scene Description Language (SDL). The language is then translated into your 3D scene. It's hardly the most convenient way of going about things, but once you get the hang of it, it works brilliantly. Professional graphics artists swear by POV-Ray, and as you see here, they know what they're talking about.

If you're interested in using POV-Ray, you should definitely learn the SDL. However, there are a lot of front-ends for it, which can export your 3D scene to SDL. Good examples are PoseRay